

The Multiplicity of Meaning, chapters 4 and 5

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1 *Explaining the speech behavior associated with vagueness*

There's another puzzle associated with vagueness, that's only tangentially related to the Sorites. In a range of cases ('borderline cases'), even well-informed speakers are averse to giving flat 'yes' and 'no' answers to a yes-no question. They prefer to *hedge*, often by offering more detail.¹ *Question:* Why do we prefer to avoid just saying 'yes' or 'no' in such cases?

Basic pluralist answer: If we said 'yes' or 'no' (without lots of clarification), we would be asserting something something false, and we don't want to do that.

Bonus: Pluralism also neatly explains another fact that some other accounts struggle with, namely that we are *also* averse to just saying 'I don't know' in these cases (without further clarification). *Explanation:* saying 'I don't know' would also involve asserting something false, since some of the propositions we were asked about are ones we *do* know (or know to be false).

Of course there are lots of other possible explanations of these familiar facts; trying to catalogue and compare them would take ages. Instead I think it's better to focus on an explanandum that's more challenging for non-pluralists: the fact that even when speakers are constrained in such a way that saying 'yes' and saying 'no' (without followup) are the only options, different speakers make different choices, even when they are very well-informed and co-operative. I call this phenomenon **forced-choice variability**.²

Forced-choice variability isn't mysterious for the pluralist. Compatibly with being "co-operative", different speakers can have different fine-grained preferences as between the deleterious consequences of saying 'no' and those of saying 'yes', even if there are no relevant differences in their beliefs.

But it's mysterious if there only one proposition *p* expressed by the question. If they all know it's the one expressed, shouldn't the policy say 'yes' if *p* and 'no' if *not-p* be a natural "co-ordination equilibrium", so if the speakers are all relevantly well-informed, they would all follow it and thus all say the same thing?

2 *The epistemicist alternative*

The monist could offer an "epistemicist" explanation: although there is a single proposition expressed (asserted, meant...), no ordinary speakers (even well-informed ones) can know whether it's true.

– This seems deeply implausible!

¹ Are most philosophy professors writers? — Well, most of them write papers and books aimed at other philosophers, but only a few write for a general audience.
Is your brother bald? — He does have a pretty big bald spot.
Are you in a relationship? — It's complicated.

² It's the basis of the argument in Williamson 1994: 199 that 'we have no idea how to conceive borderline cases in such a way that nothing in them lies hidden from ordinary speakers'.

- (i) In simple signalling systems (fruit exploration case), analogues of forced-choice variability can readily arise without relevant uncertainty; and the differences seem just a matter of degree.
- (ii) In realistic cases of forced-choice variability, the differences between different co-operative speakers' reactions are driven by differences of preference, not of credence—'Have all the cups been washed?'
- (iii) Epistemicism can't explain why it's often bad to answer 'no' to 'Do you know whether *P*?'
- (iv) The epistemicist explanation conflicts with the only workable monist response to Argument One (see last week's handout). That response involves making the following speech when one is in a specialized context: 'The property of being a cup is the one that ordinary indifferent uses of 'cup' express; it's a property that glasses instantiate [/do not instantiate], and we are in a position to know that.'

3 *Limits of this argument*

Non-epistemicist, non-pluralist response: Although there is only one proposition expressed, *expressing* plays no special role in our preference systems. Speakers don't *care* any more about avoiding sentences that *express* falsehoods than about avoiding sentences that bear any of many other one-one relations to falsehoods. So there is nothing to make 'express a truth' a co-ordination equilibrium.

– This is workable, so the argument isn't a full success. However, it concedes pluralism in the case of relations like *caring about*.

4 *Robustness versus parity*

ROBUSTNESS Often, when someone says that *p*, there was a substantial chance, well in advance, that they would say that *p*.³

One way⁴ to use robustness to argue for pluralism is to appeal to the following premise:

PARITY When propositions are extremely similar, they do not have radically dissimilar chances of being asserted.

But while Parity is attractive, the basis for it seems ultimately like a re-run of the "Problem of the Many" argument we have already set aside.

The monist (or other anti-pluralist) can say that there is a small collection of propositions that are "easy to assert"; each such proposition is asserted throughout a substantial "patch" of modal space.

A more promising way to argue from robustness to pluralism appeals to our *knowledge* of robustness. There are not-too-distant possibilities where our robustness beliefs are wrong (because we are

³ I'm talking here about objective (physical) chance, as of some time well in advance of the utterance. Maybe I should focus instead on cases where there was a *high* chance of one's asserting that *p* conditional on one's uttering a given sentence—which also seem very common!

⁴ See Dorr and Hawthorne 2014: §2.

near the edge of a patch). And these errors threaten much of our actual *knowledge* of robustness and other modal speech-act facts.

5 Troublesome errors at nearby worlds

Suppose we have a notion of ‘nearly-actualized world’, defined in precise physical terms.⁵ Say that w' is *close to* w iff w' is nearly actualized at w . Say that it is robustly the case that p iff p holds at every *nearly-actualized* possible world.⁶

Consider a long series of worlds $w_0, \dots, w_n$ beginning at the actual world, where each is close to its predecessor. At each world, Sally utters

- (1) Salad is delicious

Suppose the worlds vary in such a way that at w_n , she is not thereby asserting that salad is delicious. At each world, Fred defines ‘robustly’ as above and asserts:

- (2) Sally robustly asserts that salad is delicious.

We can flesh out the details in such a way that in each world, Fred’s basis for saying this is very strong. It would be very implausible to have to say that Fred is making a mistake somewhere.⁷ And saying this would put our whole practice of modalized speech reporting under an epistemological cloud.⁸

Is the monist stuck with this bad result? You might think so. By classical logic, there’s a last world w_i where Sally asserts that salad is delicious. At w_i , it’s false that Sally robustly asserts that salad is delicious. Doesn’t that mean that Fred is making a mistake there? No: we could say that at w_i , Fred does not assert the proposition 2 when he utters (2).

A simple compositional model: when someone utters an indexical-free sentence (in an appropriately literal way), they assert the unique proposition it semantically expresses, and nothing else. In this model, we can save Fred from error by positing that ‘asserts’ shifts its meaning before ‘salad’ and ‘delicious’ do. At w_i , Fred asserts, truly, that Sally robustly asserts* that salad is delicious.

But we can get around this response by putting the word ‘assert’ into Sally’s speech as well. In the chapter, I have Sally and Fred respectively utter:

- (3) Someone surrounded by salad is robustly⁹ asserting something.¹⁰
 (4) Sally is robustly asserting that someone surrounded by salad is robustly asserting something.

⁵ w is *nearly actualized* := for every particle x , x is a particle at w ; for any two particles x and y time t , and real number d such that the distance between x and y is d metres at t , at w the distance between x and y at t is within one nanometre of d ; there are no new particles at w ; and every law of nature is true at w .

⁶ The arguments will go through just as well if ‘robustly’ means ‘at most nearly-actualized possible worlds’, where ‘most’ is spelled out using a measure defined in precise physical terms.

⁷ I think that even apart from classical logic, there is epistemological pressure to say that Fred is *asserting something true* at all the worlds; so there may be an argument for pluralism in this vicinity that could be persuasive to some opponents of classical logic. But I won’t try to spell it out.

⁸ In response, one could insist that these possible errors should be brushed aside as mere “sceptical possibilities”: see Kearns and Magidor 2008. But this seems excessively optimistic, given how nearby they are (temporally as well as modally)!

⁹ It’s not crucial that ‘robustly’ appears in Sally’s sentence though it’s convenient for latter variants.

¹⁰ Read this with ‘something’ scoping above ‘robustly’.

Let w_j now be the last world where Sally asserts **3** with (3). Then she doesn't robustly assert it; so if Fred asserts **4** with (4), he's making a mistake (a bad result).

Why might one think he does? Thought: for Sally to still be asserting **3** with (3), w_0 must be a world where 'assert' still means *assert*, 'surrounded by salad' still means *surrounded by salad*, etc.; but then by compositionality (4) still means **4**.

But we must be careful! *Prima facie*, it assumes a fine-grained 'Structural' account of the individuation of propositions that is inconsistent because of the Russell-Myhill paradox.¹¹ Without this, we in principle have the following possibility: although at w_0 'assert' expresses a different relation, *assertion**, the proposition that someone surrounded by salad is robustly asserting* something is necessarily equivalent to, and in fact identical to, the proposition that someone surrounded by salad is robustly asserting something.

But *this is very mysterious!* We know that there is at least one proposition (namely **3**) that can be robustly asserted* without being robustly asserted (since that's what happens at w_0). If this can happen at all, why can't it happen when the proposition in question is the only one ever asserted by anyone surrounded by salad?

- In the chapter, I dramatize this problem by considering a version of the argument where, at all worlds in the series, Sally's utterance of (3) is the one and only utterance made by someone surrounded by salad. On the simple compositional model, there's no way to avoid attributing error to Fred in this case.

Can we get around the problem by abandoning the simple compositional model, instead allowing 'assert' to vary in an indexical-like way even within a world? It's hard to see how this would work. Moreover, it'll run into trouble when we use anaphora to enforce co-ordinated interpretation across the speeches:

- (3') *Asserting* and *being a person surrounded by salad* are, respectively, a relation and a property such that some instance of that property robustly bears that relation to some proposition.
- (4') Moreover, some instance of that property robustly bears that relation to the proposition that some instance of that property robustly bears that relation to some proposition.

6 How does pluralism get around the problem?

A "mechanical" version of pluralism: setting aside certain special indexical words that do not appear in any of our sentences, when you utter a sentence assertively, you assert *all and only* the propositions it semantically expresses.

This does not avoid error. At the last world where Sally asserts **3** with (3), 'assert' will (inter alia) express *asserting*, 'salad' will (inter

¹¹ Certain implementations of 'guise-sensitivity' might allow us to avoid appealing to Structure here; but they are controversial and I don't want my arguments against monism to rest on them.

alia) express *being salad*.... So, (4) will (inter alia) express the false proposition 4, and Fred will be making a mistake when he asserts it.

What we need is a *non-mechanical* model that allows for fine-grained, evidence-sensitive variation in the range of propositions asserted by a given utterance of a declarative sentence.

Then we can say that people reporting other people's speeches homophonically, who are broadly but not perfectly sensitive to their circumstances, generally use words in the scope of verbs like 'assert' to express a "safe core" of the larger cloud of meanings expressed by the corresponding word-occurrences in the reported utterance.

7 Problems with modalized speech reports in the actual world

To solve metaphysical Tolerance Puzzles¹², we need to posit so much semantic plasticity in ordinary count nouns that unless pluralism is true, our cross-world reporting practices are radically error-ridden *in the actual world*.

b is bench-tolerant := *b* is a bench on my roof, and for any six planks $p_1 \dots p_6$ on my roof, if at least five of $p_1 \dots p_6$ are parts of *b*, then it is possible that $p_1 \dots p_6$ originally compose *b* while *b* is a bench on my roof and the collection of all planks on my roof is the same.

Tolerance: Every bench on my roof is *bench-tolerant*.

Non-hypertolerance: Neither bench could have been originally composed by the six planks that in fact originally composed the other bench.

- (i) Given Tolerance and Non-hypertolerance, there must be a largest number $0 < n < 6$ such that each bench could have been a bench made of any *n* of its actual planks together with any $6 - n$ of the other planks.¹³
- (ii) If one of the benches were a bench made of *n* of its actual planks together with $6 - n$ of the other bench's actual planks, it would not be bench-tolerant, since it couldn't have been originally composed by collections comprising $n - 1$ of its actual planks and $7 - n$ of the other planks.
- (iii) That could easily have happened.
- (iv) But I would still have been disposed to utter *(Tolerance) in that case. And I wouldn't have been making a mistake—the random way I grouped the planks wasn't just a lucky break as regards my capacity to form accurate beliefs about the modal properties of benches!¹⁴
- (v) So in such worlds, I wouldn't have thereby asserted that every bench on my roof was bench-tolerant. Our favoured view explains this by saying that my use of 'bench' in uttering Tolerance would not have referred to *being a bench*.¹⁵

¹² See Dorr, Hawthorne, and Yli-Vakkuri 2021.

¹³ A good question: could anything in the vicinity of the present argument be convincing to those who give up classical logic in response to the Sorites?

¹⁴ Someone could dig their heels in here and insist that we just are really lucky. But this seems way worse than the luck-embracing response to the previous argument. These are *extremely* close possibilities!

¹⁵ Context: a "plenitudinous" ontology where every concrete object coincides with a vast horde of others, with a whole spectrum of different modal profiles.

- (vi) But that use of ‘bench’ would have referred to *some* property *B*. Moreover, it wouldn’t have been a semantic outlier: if there is a unique property referred to by *typical* uses of ‘bench’ in those worlds, *B* is such a property.
- (vii) So, *given monism*, it’s false that *being a bench* is referred to by typical uses of ‘bench’ in these worlds. Result: rampant *actual* errors in claims of the form ‘I would likely have said that *P* no matter how I had grouped the planks’, where *P* includes the word ‘bench’.

Even pluralists have to posit a *little* error, since we’re initially inclined to think that I’d have said that *every bench my roof was bench-tolerant* no matter how I had grouped the planks. This is just a mistake. But such mistakes need not be pervasive; they can be avoided without radical revision.¹⁶

8 Consequences for language-of-thought theories of attitudes

¹⁶ *Typical* uses of ‘bench’ in the worlds in question, as in ‘Every bench on my roof is six feet long’ or ‘*Banc* expresses the property of being a bench’, refer to *being a bench* as well as to the properties whose instances are tolerant.

There is a good case that those uses refer to *all* of the many properties that would be referred to by uses of ‘bench’ in Tolerance-speeches made in worlds with different plank-arrangements.

References

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